a position of hope'. Drawing on the BI manager Varaprasadam Pillai's testimony in court, it said that except for a few merchants all others were using only Swadeshi steamers. It even gave numbers: BI could not be carrying more than 200 to 300 bags per voyage. In carrying piece goods too, SSNCo had a lead with its average income per trip at least five times more than that of BI. Exploiting its full control of 'the coolie traffic' to the plantations, BI was using this advantage to cut cargo rates. Once SSNCo began regular daily service, *The Hindu* claimed, the game would change.[52]

Another report, published in the moderate *Indian Review*, also painted a positive picture. For 'local cargo', the Swadeshi company was charging full rates that were levied by BI before the rate war began while the latter had cut it down to half. The 'hopeful feature' was that all Indian merchants, with only a few exceptions, were shipping through the Swadeshi steamers unmindful of the expense. For 'through goods', while the Swadeshi company was charging 3 annas (36 paise), the British company was charging a throw-away price of only 11 paise (five paisa less than one anna). 'On the whole', it was said, the Swadeshi company earned more than five times the British company on cargo, while BI had practically no competition in passenger traffic as SSNCo could not run a daily service.[53]

If *The Hindu* and the *Indian Review* tried to reason it out with facts and figures, the poet, Bharati, took the sentimental route.

> Sriman Chidambaram Pillai, who was like a father unto the Tuticorin steamship company, has been removed from our midst, and has thus been prevented from devoting his philanthropic energies [to the Swadeshi cause]. In these times, it is therefore the primary duty of every Indian to nurture his doting daughter, the shipping company. If the company were to suffer in any manner due to negligence on our part in his absence, more damage to our national pride can scarcely be imagined.[54]

Bharati also drew the attention of his readers to the *Bande Mataram*'s ridicule of people in Madras for letting down the Swadeshi company.[55] Bharati was using every rhetorical device to prod the public to shell out money.